

Hardship and upheaval

The family returned to Poland, where Witold learned the piano and the violin, and went on to earn diplomas in piano and composition from the Warsaw Conservatory. By the end of the 1930s, his reputation was growing, despite military service, when Poland was invaded simultaneously by Germany and Russia. In 1939, while serving as a radio operator, he was captured by German troops, but escaped and returned to Warsaw. Here, he teamed up with pianist and composer Andrzej Panufnik to make a living performing as a piano duo in cafés in the city. The pair made numerous arrangements of popular classics, as well as some original compositions, but little of this music survived the war.

Warsaw became unsafe, and Lutosławski and his mother fled the city before its complete devastation during the Warsaw Uprising in 1944, and did not return until after the war. The comparative stability of Poland as a Soviet satellite gave him the opportunity to settle down. In 1945, he married Maria Danuta Bogusławska, and with her assistance started to compose in earnest. He had begun work on his first major work, the Symphony No. 1, in 1941, but with the distraction of working as a jobbing composer, only completed it in 1947. There were additional constraints: the Stalinist insistence on socialist realism in music led to Lutosławski being branded a Formalist composer, and he was denied the freedom to compose as he wished.